

Chicago Tribune



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BREAKING NEWS AT CHICAGOTRIBUNE.COM

GENERAL ASSEMBLY

At 11th hour, budget plan emerges



Democrats likely to adhere to Pritzker's outline, as lawmakers weigh ideas to bring cash to state

By Dan Petrella, Jeremy Gorner, Olivia Olander and Addison Wright
Chicago Tribune

SPRINGFIELD — Democratic state lawmakers worked for most of the day Friday behind closed doors as they sought to build consensus on a roughly \$55 billion state spending plan that will require a combination of about

\$1 billion in cuts and revenue increases to come into balance.

A budget bill was finally produced early Friday evening, a little more than 24 hours before the legislative deadline to pass a spending plan.

The final package was likely to stick closely to the broad outlines of the plan Gov. JB Pritzker presented to lawmakers in February. However, with revenue

projections for the budget year that begins July 1 dimming in the months since the governor made his proposal, legislators also were considering some new ideas to bring in more money to the state, including changes that would allow Illinois to tax offshore and out-of-state corporate profits.

Aside from wrangling over the state's main operating budget, lawmakers continued to work on a plan to overhaul governance and increase funding for Chicago-area

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Senate President Don Harmon, left, and House Speaker Emanuel "Chris" Welch, right, exit Gov. JB Pritzker's office after a meeting at the Illinois State Capitol in Springfield on Friday. **JOHN J. KIM/CHICAGO TRIBUNE**

Arts chief touts vision

Hedspeth fires back at critics, lauds gains in grants for artists

By Jake Sheridan
Chicago Tribune

As Chicago's Department of Cultural Affairs and Special Events gears up for another highlight-packed summer, its leader is laying out her vision for the city's arts community as



Hedspeth

she responds to criticism that has been simmering since she took office.

A contentious exhibition, staff complaints and public flak from some arts leaders have tailed DCASE Commissioner Clinée Hedspeth since her March 2024 appointment by Mayor Brandon Johnson. Addressing the controversies in an interview with the Tribune for the first time, Hedspeth said she has reflected, but pushed back against much of it as unfounded.

"I think I did walk into a hostile situation," she said.

Meanwhile, Hedspeth is doubling down on a top focus to get artists more money. The department has earmarked an extra \$500,000 for grants to artists, in addition to the \$7 million allocated by the City Council last fall, she said.

"As much as we talk about water services, as much as we talk about infrastructure, this is the same. This is on par," Hedspeth said of direct payments to artists and small arts organizations. "This is vital. This is a service to be able to provide people with funding to create and capture who we are as a city."

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TERRENCE ANTONIO JAMES/CHICAGO TRIBUNE

Not fat, just shell-padded

Temperatures may still be hovering in the 60s, but one more sure sign of summer's arrival has graced Chicago: Chonkosaurus has risen. The famed snapping turtle, dubbed "Chonkosaurus" by internet commentators when pictures of her basking on a Chicago River pylon went viral in summer 2023, reappeared earlier this week, resting above in the North Branch Canal on Thursday. The celebrity turtle and at least two companions spent the winter in brumation, a period of low activity akin to hibernation. Steven Meyer, of the nonprofit organization Urban Rivers, said a Shedd Aquarium employee caught the first conclusive pictures of the season, which show a notch in the back right portion of the reptile's shell. Meyer said three snapping turtles have recently been hanging out near Goose Island, making it more of a challenge to identify Chonkosaurus. Chonk and another large, but not as large, turtle known as Staggy have both been visible over the last week, he said, but he was only able to definitively confirm which turtle was which on Thursday.

— Caroline Kubzansky

500K migrants in US lose legal safeguards

By Lindsay Whitehurst
Associated Press

WASHINGTON — The Supreme Court again cleared the way Friday for the Trump administration to strip temporary legal protections from hundreds of thousands of immigrants for now, pushing the total number

of people who could be newly exposed to deportation to nearly 1 million.

The justices lifted a lower court order that kept humanitarian parole protections in place for more than 500,000 migrants from four countries: Cuba, Haiti, Nicaragua and Venezuela. The decision comes after the court allowed

the administration to revoke temporary legal status from about 350,000 Venezuelan migrants in another case.

The court did not explain its reasoning in the brief order, as is typical on its emergency docket. Two justices publicly dissented.

The administration filed an emergency appeal to the Supreme

Court after a federal judge in Boston blocked the administration's push to end the program. The Justice Department argues that the protections for people fleeing turmoil in their home countries were always meant to be temporary, and the Department of

Turn to Migrants, Page 6

Penny heads to the great piggy bank in the sky

By Joseph States

Check under the couch cushions and dig through your coat pockets because the era of America's one-cent coin, colloquially known as the penny, is coming to a close.

The Treasury Department recently confirmed production

of the penny will end next year, almost 240 years after the first U.S. pennies were minted. Few are decrying the move, perhaps a sign of its long overdue retirement.

It turns out that pennies are more expensive to mint than they're actually worth, and there have been calls for their demise going back decades.

The saying "a penny for your thoughts," which traces its origins to the 16th century — if adjusted for inflation from 1909 when the first modern American penny was minted — would be closer to two quarters, although no one is paying that kind of money for thoughts these days.

The penny is not the first coin

to go to the great piggy bank in the sky. Among the discontinued is the half-cent coin, which ended production in 1857, and the two- and three-cent coins were stopped in 1873 and 1889, respectively. There was even a 20-cent coin, although it was only

Turn to Penny, Page 4

INSIDE

Cardoso's big game a reason for hope?



In the team's first win of the season Thursday night, Kamilla Cardoso gave the Sky what they have been seeking ever since they drafted the Brazilian center with the No. 3 pick last spring. **Chicago Sports**

TODAY'S WEATHER



High 66 Low 49

Complete Chicagoland forecast on Page 8

\$4.00 city and suburbs and elsewhere
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